

## Overthinking is injurious to mental health

Overthinking is a **subtle** but destructive habit that many people silently suffer from. It often **disguises** itself as caution or deep **reflection**, but in truth, it's a mental loop that traps individuals in cycles of worry, doubt, and inaction. While it may seem like a method of preparation or problem-solving, overthinking is far from harmless — it quietly **undermines** peace of mind, self-confidence, relationships, and even opportunities.

What begins as a desire to make the right choice or prepare for future outcomes quickly **spirals** into obsessive thinking. The mind replays conversations, **dissects** every detail, and invents endless “what ifs” and “should haves.”

Instead of arriving at clarity, individuals find themselves **stuck in** a loop of mental noise that prevents real progress. A **2013 study** published in the Journal of Abnormal Psychology **found** that overthinking is closely linked with anxiety and depression. Repetitive negative thinking was shown to be a shared factor in many mental health issues. This **highlights** that overthinking isn't just an annoying **quirk** — it's a serious risk factor that drains emotional energy, **limits** engagement with real life, and **inhibits** personal growth. Overthinkers often question every decision they make, fearing failure or embarrassment. This **undermines** self-trust, making even small choices feel high-stakes. When someone begins to believe that every decision must be perfect, they become **paralysed** by the fear of **imperfection**, holding themselves back from growth, both personally and professionally. Relationships are also affected. Overthinkers tend to overanalyse texts, tones, or expressions, often creating negative narratives. A delayed **response** from a friend **can** spiral into “They're mad at me,” or “I must've said something wrong.” These imagined scenarios create emotional distance, tension, and unnecessary stress, making it hard to connect authentically. On top of that, the constant mental activity can interfere with sleep, leading to **insomnia** or disrupted rest, which further affects emotional well-being. So what fuels this habit of overthinking? At its core, overthinking is **driven** by fear — the fear of failure, of being judged, of losing control.

Often, these fears **stem from** past experiences where mistakes were punished or outcomes were unpredictable. As a **coping mechanism**, the brain tries to take control by **playing out** every possible scenario. **Ironically**, this **attempt** at control **results in** more **chaos** and mental **fatigue**. To escape the grip of overthinking, the first step is awareness. You can't change what you don't recognise. Start by observing your thought patterns and identifying when helpful **reflection** turns into **rumination**. The next step is to disrupt the cycle. One effective technique is to set a “thinking deadline.” **For instance**, give yourself 30 minutes to evaluate a decision, **weigh the pros and cons**, and then make a choice. This method trains your brain to move from over analysis to action. Journaling is another powerful tool. Writing down your thoughts gets them out of your head and onto paper, immediately reducing their emotional charge. It also engages the logical part of the brain, helping you process emotions more **constructively**.

**Cognitive-behavioural therapy** (CBT), a scientifically supported method, **is** built around this very idea — challenging **irrational** thoughts and replacing them with more realistic, balanced perspectives. Most importantly, take action. Overthinking **convinces** us to wait until we feel perfectly ready, but clarity often comes after we start. Even the smallest **step** — sending a message, making a phone call, beginning a project — **can** break the mental **gridlock** and build momentum.

We begin to see that the consequences of our decisions are rarely as **catastrophic** as we imagine, and even when things go wrong, we gain experience and **resilience**. Building trust in yourself is crucial. Each small, confident decision **reinforces** your capability. Along the way, practising self-compassion helps loosen the grip of **perfectionism**. You don't need to be **flawless** or have all the answers. Life is unpredictable by nature, and **embracing** that truth allows space for peace and growth. In the end, overthinking **drains** our most valuable resources — time and mental peace. It **disguises** itself as preparation but only delays action and postpones growth. Life isn't meant to be overanalysed — it's meant to be lived fully and authentically. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

## Vocabulary

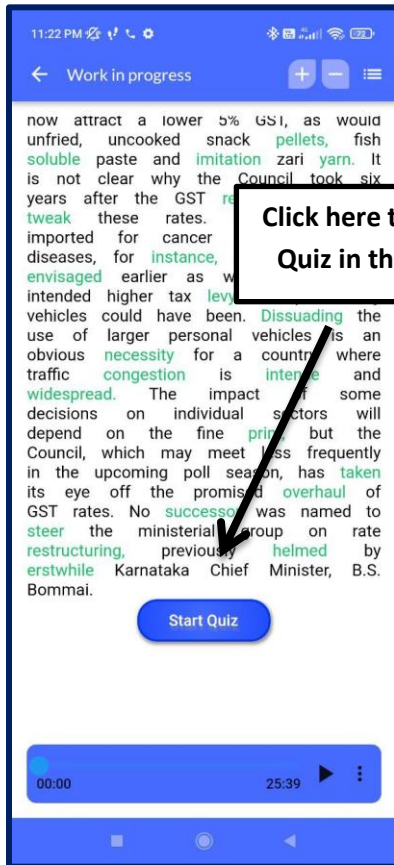
1. **Subtle** (adjective) – delicate, faint, slight, nuanced, understated सूक्ष्म
2. **Disguise** (verb) – conceal, hide, mask, cloak, veil छिपाना
3. **Reflection** (noun) – contemplation, meditation, consideration, thought, introspection चिंतन / विचार
4. **Undermine** (verb) – weaken, erode, sabotage, impair, diminish कमजोर करना
5. **Spiral** (verb) – escalate, intensify, snowball, accelerate, surge तेजी से बढ़ना / नियंत्रण से बाहर होना
6. **Dissect** (verb) – analyze, examine, deconstruct, investigate, break down विश्लेषण करना
7. **Stuck** (in) (adjective) – trapped, caught, immobilized, fixed, jammed फंसा हुआ
8. **Highlight** (verb) – emphasize, stress, underline, showcase, bring attention to जोर देना
9. **Quirk** (noun) – peculiarity, oddity, eccentricity, idiosyncrasy, trait अजीब आदत / विशेषता
10. **Limit** (verb) – restrict, constrain, curb, reduce, confine सीमित करना
11. **Inhibit** (verb) – hinder, restrain, block, suppress, prevent रोकना / बाधा डालना
12. **Paralyse** (verb) – immobilize, incapacitate, disable, freeze, stun पक्षाघात करना / जड़ करना
13. **Imperfection** (noun) – flaw, defect, blemish, shortcoming, weakness त्रुटि
14. **Insomnia** (noun) – sleeplessness, wakefulness, restlessness, disturbed sleep, inability to sleep अनिद्रा
15. **Drive** (verb) – motivate, compel, propel, influence, stimulate प्रेरित करना
16. **Stem** (from) (verb) – originate, arise, derive, emerge, result से उत्पन्न होना
17. **Coping** (adjective) – managing, handling, adapting, dealing, enduring मुकाबला करने वाला
18. **Mechanism** (noun) – process, system, method, structure, apparatus प्रणाली / तंत्र
19. **Play out** (phrasal verb) – unfold, occur, happen, materialize, take place घटित होना / अंजाम तक पहुँचना
20. **Ironically** (adverb) – paradoxically, unexpectedly, absurdly, strangely, humorously विडंबना से
21. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – cause, lead to, bring about, produce, trigger के परिणामस्वरूप होना

22. **Chaos** (noun) – disorder, confusion, turmoil, mayhem, anarchy अराजकता / अव्यवस्था
23. **Fatigue** (noun) – exhaustion, tiredness, weariness, burnout, lethargy थकावट
24. **Rumination** (noun) – brooding, overthinking, dwelling, obsessive thought, contemplation बार-बार विचार करना
25. **For instance** (phrase) – for example, such as, like, to illustrate, namely उदाहरण के लिए
26. **Weigh** (verb) – consider, evaluate, assess, balance, appraise विचार करना
27. **The pros and cons** (phrase) – advantages and disadvantages, positives and negatives, benefits and drawbacks फायदे और नुकसान
28. **Constructively** (adverb) – productively, positively, usefully, effectively, helpfully रचनात्मक रूप से
29. **Irrational** (adjective) – unreasonable, illogical, senseless, absurd, ungrounded तर्कहीन
30. **Convince** (verb) – persuade, assure, influence, sway, win over समझाना / मनाना
31. **Gridlock** (noun) – deadlock, stalemate, standstill, jam, bottleneck गतिरोध
32. **Catastrophic** (adjective) – disastrous, devastating, ruinous, tragic, calamitous विनाशकारी
33. **Resilience** (noun) – strength, toughness, adaptability, endurance, recovery मज़बूती
34. **Reinforce** (verb) – strengthen, support, bolster, fortify, solidify मजबूत करना
35. **Perfectionism** (noun) – flawlessness, idealism, exactitude, precisionism, fastidiousness पूर्णतावाद
36. **Flawless** (adjective) – perfect, immaculate, impeccable, unblemished, faultless निर्दोष / त्रुटिहीन
37. **Embrace** (verb) – accept, adopt, welcome, include, take on अपनाना
38. **Drain** (verb) – deplete, exhaust, sap, empty, consume समाप्त करना

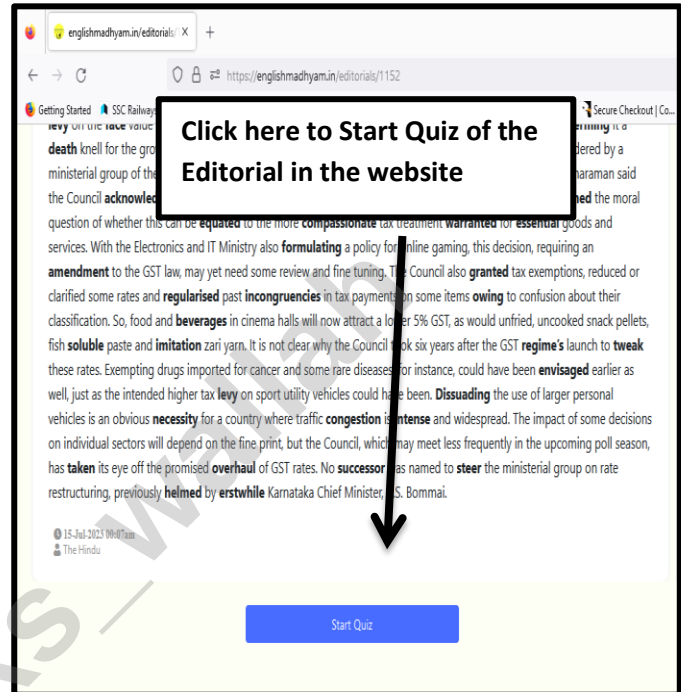
### Summary of the Editorial

1. **Overthinking is Destructive** – It masquerades as caution but traps people in cycles of worry, doubt, and inaction.
2. **False Problem-Solving** – Unlike productive reflection, overthinking creates mental noise without leading to clarity.
3. **Linked to Anxiety & Depression** – Studies show repetitive negative thinking worsens mental health.
4. **Drains Emotional Energy** – It exhausts the mind, leaving little room for real-life engagement.
5. **Undermines Self-Trust** – Overthinkers second-guess decisions, making even small choices feel overwhelming.
6. **Fear of Imperfection** – The pursuit of perfect decisions leads to paralysis and missed opportunities.
7. **Harms Relationships** – Overanalyzing texts, tones, and actions creates unnecessary tension.
8. **Causes Sleep Issues** – Constant mental chatter disrupts rest, worsening emotional well-being.
9. **Rooted in Fear** – Fear of failure, judgment, or losing control fuels overthinking.
10. **Past Experiences Play a Role** – Previous mistakes or unpredictability condition the brain to overanalyze.
11. **Awareness is Key** – Recognizing overthinking is the first step to breaking the cycle.
12. **Set a "Thinking Deadline"** – Limiting decision-making time forces action instead of endless analysis.
13. **Journaling Helps** – Writing thoughts down reduces their emotional intensity and engages logic.
14. **Take Action, Even Small Steps** – Movement breaks mental gridlock and builds confidence.
15. **Self-Compassion & Acceptance** – Embracing imperfection and unpredictability leads to peace and growth.

## Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



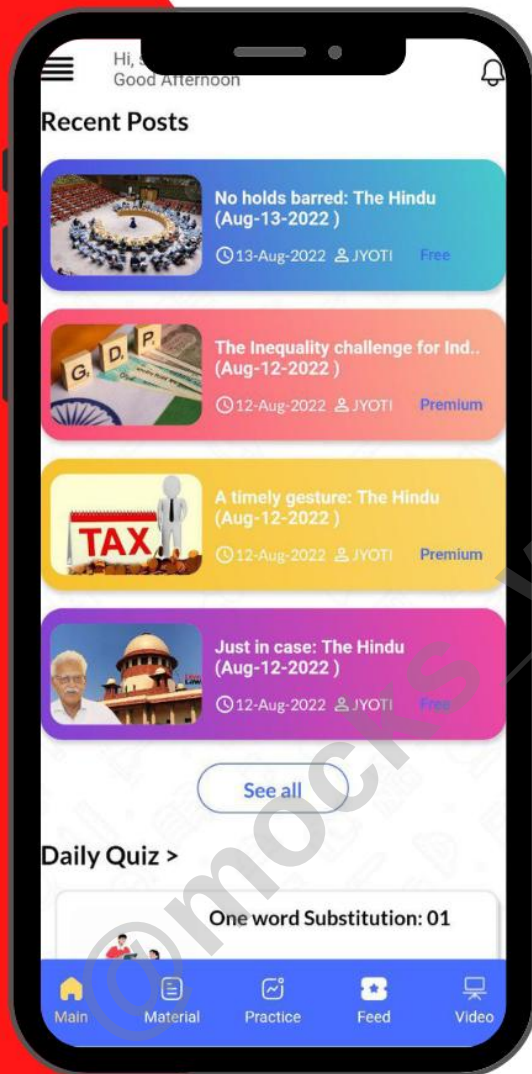
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